

The Last Night — Alexander's Timeline

Compiled by Alexander, house manager, Sunday morning between 7:42 AM and 9:30 AM. To be shared with the family before the Sheriff arrives. Based on my photographs, my notes, and brief conversations with each guest at breakfast. I have flagged gaps where my observation is incomplete. Where two of you remember the same moment differently, I've written both.

— A.

Friday evening (for context)

- **6:00 PM** — Mr. Crookshank arrives, alone, in the silver sedan. Solomon in his cage. The leather portfolio. A case of glass-bottle root beer. The notarized envelope, which he placed on the dining room sideboard “where everyone could see it.”
- **7:30 PM** — Family dinner. Mr. Crookshank gives gifts at the table: a vintage bottle of orange blossom water to Catherine; a small leather-bound book of poems, privately, to Eden after dinner; a “Beau Thats Hot” pitch is mocked at the table after Beau brings it up. Hank lays down the “no politics in this house” rule when Mr. Crookshank brings up Olympia.
- **10:30 PM** — Lights out for most. Solomon was on his perch in the gazebo overnight.

Saturday

Morning and afternoon

- **8:00 AM** — Breakfast. Mr. Crookshank had two glass-bottle root beers and complained the lake was “shaped wrong.”
- **10:00 AM - 1:00 PM** — Lake activities. Sebastian and Hank took out the speedboat. Vivi and Catherine were on the deck. Beau, Levi, Cody, and Eden played a long game of beach volleyball. Bella was in the kitchen with me prepping food for the evening.
- **1:00 PM** — Lunch. Sandwiches on the patio. Mr. Crookshank ate two and then disappeared into the guest room until 3.
- **~2:15 PM** — *Gap.* I was on the south lawn refilling the firewood rack. I do not know who was in the main house during this stretch. Cody mentioned he was “around” upstairs. Eden says she was “reading.” Beau says he was napping on the patio chair, but the chair didn’t look slept-in.
- **3:00 PM** — Mr. Crookshank reappears. He pulls Vivi aside for a private conversation in the den. *Catherine asked me later what they were talking about. I told her I didn’t know.* Vivi told me at breakfast this morning he was “telling her how proud he was of her.”
- **3:30 PM** — Vivi walks alone down to the boathouse. I see her from the kitchen window. She is there for about two hours. Sebastian joins her at some point — I did

not see when. By 5:00 PM they were both back at the main house.

- **5:30 PM** — Bella comes up from the gazebo looking upset. She tells me she “needs ten minutes.” When I asked her later, at breakfast, she said it was a phone call with her boss. (*Note from A.: Bella, I want to be honest — I checked the call log on the landline phone in the gazebo, and there were no calls placed from it between 5 and 6 PM. I am not accusing you of anything. I am just noting it.*)

Evening

- **6:00 PM** — Mocktail hour on the patio. Mr. Crookshank held court. Solomon was on the railing.
- **7:00 PM** — *Gap*. I was inside finalizing the bonfire setup. Mr. Crookshank went to the gazebo. He was alone — or so I thought. Bella tells me this morning she was with him in the gazebo for “about ten minutes” having a conversation. Mr. Crookshank told me, when he came back, that he had been “alone with Solomon, mostly.”
- **7:30 PM** — Dinner. Grilled food at the long table. Mr. Crookshank gave a toast about “this lovely family that has so generously claimed me.” He laughed at his own joke. Hank did not.
- **8:00 PM** — Hank and Mr. Crookshank both leave the table within five minutes of each other. I see Hank walking toward the gazebo. I do not see Mr. Crookshank between 8:00 and 8:30. Hank tells me at breakfast he was “stretching his legs by the gazebo.” Mr. Crookshank, at 8:30, came back to the patio with a small tear in his green tweed jacket. He said he “caught it on a nail.”
- **8:30 PM - 9:00 PM** — Lawn games. Cornhole, mostly. Cody and Levi tossing a football off to the side. Beau joining and leaving.
- **9:00 PM** — Bonfire lit. Catherine started tending. Hank joined her. Most of the family rotated in and out.
- **9:00 PM - 9:30 PM** — Mr. Crookshank was in the gazebo with Solomon. I brought him a glass-bottle root beer and a small plate. He thanked me. He said: “*You are the best of them, Alexander.*” I did not know what to do with that.
- **9:30 PM - 9:45 PM** — *Gap in the main house*. I was at the bonfire. Catherine had stepped away briefly — she told me at breakfast she was “looking for a notebook in the den.” Eden was, by her own account, “in the bottom-floor games room with Beau,” but Beau says he was on the patio. They cannot both be right.
- **10:00 PM** — Mr. Crookshank discovered his case of root beer missing from the kitchen. He shouted at me about it. He shouted at Solomon about it. Solomon agreed.
- **10:00 PM - 12:30 AM** — *Gap*. Levi was, by his account, “on the porch with me looking at the stars.” I will not contradict him in this document. (*Privately to the family: I covered for him. I am sorry. I did not know what for. I will make this right.*)
- **10:30 PM** — Bella joined the bonfire. She told me she was “fine.” She did not look fine.
- **11:00 PM** — Hank and Catherine moved from the bonfire to the patio sofa together.

I have a photograph of them at 11:08 PM. They are holding hands. They are not looking at each other.

- **11:00 PM** — Mr. Crookshank walked from the gazebo into the main house. He returned five minutes later with the leather portfolio under his arm. He looked, for the first time all weekend, nervous.
- **11:15 PM** — Eden, by her account, “went to her room to change shoes.” She came back at 11:25. I did not see her between those times.
- **11:30 PM** — Vivi gathered everyone at the bonfire “for one last s’more.” She launched into a long story about a Broadway opening she’d been to. The story was extremely detailed. She was an excellent storyteller. *(Note from A. at breakfast: Hank, you mentioned to me that this was the same story Vivi told at last Christmas dinner. I have not verified this. You said you were certain.)*
- **11:30 PM** — Mr. Crookshank walked alone to the dock. He told me as he passed: “I need ten minutes to rehearse. Don’t let anyone interrupt.” I told him I wouldn’t. I went to the kitchen to start the post-bonfire cleanup. The dock was out of my sightline.
- **11:35 PM** — Group photograph at the bonfire. I took it. Six people: Hank, Catherine, Vivi, Beau, Eden, Bella. Vivi is mid-gesture, mouth open, telling the story. **Sebastian is not in this photo.** Sebastian told the group he was “stepping outside for some air.”
- **11:50 PM** — Sebastian returned to the bonfire. I saw him from the kitchen window. He sat down next to Vivi. He was, by his own description, “fine.” *(Note from A.: Sebastian, you told me at breakfast you’d had a quick smoke. I checked the patio and the deck this morning for cigarette ash. I did not find any.)*
- **11:55 PM** — Vivi excused herself briefly. I saw her go upstairs. She came back down at 12:02 AM. She said she “needed a glass of water.” She told me, just now at breakfast, that she’d “felt the wine going to her head,” though we are a dry house.
- **11:59 PM** — Fireworks. (Pre-scheduled, automatic launch from the lakeside.) Cody had set the timer Friday and was very proud of it.
- **Midnight** — Mr. Crookshank was supposed to be on the dock for the reveal. He was not. Hank said: “He’s late.” Catherine said: “He’ll come.” No one walked down to check. By 12:15 the family had decided he’d changed his mind. By 12:30 the bonfire was put out and everyone went inside.

Sunday morning

- **7:42 AM** — I found Mr. Crookshank in the shallows beside the dock. The brass cleat at the end of the dock was missing. The bolts were still in the wood. His leather portfolio was open in the gazebo. The notarized envelope was gone. Solomon was screaming.
- **8:30 AM** — I called Dr. Langford. Time of death between 11:30 PM and midnight.
- **9:30 AM** — This document.

Things I cannot account for

In the interest of honesty I want to name the gaps:

1. **The 2 PM to 3 PM window upstairs.** I was outside. Several of you were inside. I do not know who was where.
2. **The 7 PM gazebo period.** Two people have told me different things about whether they were there.
3. **The 8 PM tear in Mr. Crookshank's jacket.** "A nail" is a possible explanation. So is a person.
4. **The 9:30 PM gap in the main house.** Eden and Beau cannot both be telling the truth about being in the same place at the same time.
5. **The 11:30 to 11:50 dock period.** This is the most important gap. Mr. Crookshank was alone on the dock. The cleat was pulled loose during this window. Whoever did it had to leave the bonfire and walk to the dock and come back without being seen by the bonfire group. Sebastian was not at the bonfire during these twenty minutes. I make no accusation. I note the fact.
6. **The 11:55 PM trip upstairs by Vivi.** I do not know what she did upstairs. The primary suite has a balcony overlooking the dock.
7. **Solomon.** He has been muttering since I picked him up at 8 AM. He repeats things. Some of them are clear. Most of them are not. He is, I have learned, an unreliable witness — but he is also the only one besides Mr. Crookshank who was on the dock end of the property at all times last night.

A note from me, personally

I have worked for the Whitfields for four years. I love this family. I do not enjoy writing this document. I want the Sheriff to find the truth, and I want everyone in this house to leave it on Monday morning still loving each other.

I will be in the kitchen with the coffee. Find me with questions.

— Alexander